



FINAL CLOSE-OUT REPORT

MANCOSA Mentorship Programme

2025 Cohort 2

September 2025



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Background

The MANCOSA Mentorship Programme continues to highlight the power and importance of mentorship. Cohort 7, in particular, has demonstrated that when a single life is touched through the reciprocal sharing of knowledge, skills, and experience, the impact extends far beyond the individual, it brings people together, unites communities, and creates collective growth.

Cohort 2 of 2025 marks the 7th cohort of the programme since its inception. In this report, we outline the programme's approach and project plan, participation and attendance, the impact achieved, and lessons learned. We also include recommendations from programme participants to help strengthen and sustain the programme for future cohorts.

Approach and project plan

The table below shows an overview of the 2025 cohort 2 project plan and timelines.

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Finalise programme design, set up project and governance structure

- **Programme design** - Drawing on lessons from the 2024 cohorts, we refined the structure for 2025 Cohort 1 and subsequently Cohort 2, adding further enhancements. These included earlier onboarding to improve readiness, keeping breakout rooms open for easier access during group sessions, providing clearer structures for mentor–mentee engagement, and setting expectations more effectively through briefings, debriefs, and defined deliverables.
- **Commitment agreement** - We noted from previous cohorts that attendance was high at the first session but declined from the third one. We therefore introduced a commitment agreement penalising participants who attend less than 80% of the sessions.
- **Set up project and governance** - We continued weekly and then fortnightly minuted operations meetings, supported by a programme development update report summary. This practice, proven effective in earlier cohorts, ensured coordination, accountability, and alignment within the team.

- **Flexible scheduling** - Feedback from previous cohorts showed that many participants missed sessions due to time constraints and conflicting calendars. To address this, we introduced two time slots to accommodate different schedules; an earlier option on Tuesdays (17:00–18:30) and a later option on Wednesdays (16:00–17:30).

Update programme material

As with previous cohorts, we updated the programme material to incorporate key learnings and feedback. For this cohort, the programme facilitator reviewed the workbooks and adjusted them to better suit the audience. In this case, the Mancosa Mentorship Programme was tailored for MBA students.

Identify, orient, and mobilise group mentors/mobilise, select, and orient mentees

- We sent the mentor appeal to the Mancosa alumni database and the mentee appeal to Mancosa MBA students. In addition, we accepted eight undergraduate students whose strong motivations stood out.
- We kept applications open for a month and sent WhatsApp real-time reminders and updates.
- We required the applicants to submit a video or audio motivation to judge commitment and narrowed to a final selection of 30 mentors and 39 mentees.
- We invited mentors and mentees to attend the programme participation briefing session, where they were asked to sign the programme commitment agreements before participating in the programme.

Match mentors and mentees

We matched participants by aligning mentors' skills and experience with the goals and aspirations of mentees. To enrich the learning experience, we intentionally paired individuals at different qualification levels, bringing diverse perspectives into the groups. This approach, first applied in the 2025 Cohort 1, was continued in Cohort 2 to ensure consistency and impact

Train mentors

Roslyn Solomon facilitated the first two mentor training sessions, equipping mentors to support their mentees effectively throughout the journey. Dave then led the final session, providing practical guidance on how mentors can acknowledge their mentees and agree on the way forward.

Session 1 – Sharing stories, current situation, vision & purpose
Date: 11 June, Wednesday

Session 2 – SMART goals, prioritizing time, and a growth mindset
Date: 9 July, Wednesday

Session 3 – Creative tension, self-belief, review & planning
Date: 30 August, Wednesday

Mentor feedback emphasized community, and mutual growth, while also noting early challenges with time management, unequal participation, mentee

expectations, and engagement levels, which improved as the programme progressed.

Group sessions

We continued this approach for the 2025 Cohort 2, conducting six sessions across four phases. Each session began with a group briefing and ended with a debrief, allowing participants to reflect and prepare for the next stage.



Session 1	Session 2	Session 3
Phase: Reflection	Phase: Aspiration	Phase: Aspiration
Focus Area: Journaling, River of Life	Focus Area: Wheel of Life, Purpose, Mindfulness	Focus Area: SMART Goals, Priority Matrix
Timing: June 17 & 18, Tues/Wed	Timing: July 1 & 2, Tues/Wed	Timing: July 15 & 16, Tues/Wed
Session 4	Session 5	Session 6
Phase: Transformation	Phase: Transformation	Phase: Continuation
Focus Area: Growth Mindset, Grit, Review	Focus Area: Creative Tension, Self-belief	Focus Area: Identity, Gratitude, Way Forward
Timing: July 29 & 30, Tues/Wed	Timing: August 12 & 13, Tues/Wed	Timing: August 26 & 27, Tues/Wed

Keep ongoing, contact

We set up a WhatsApp group for all mentors and another for all mentees to share updates, tips, and words of encouragement. In addition, each mentorship group had its own dedicated WhatsApp group, allowing discussions to continue beyond the scheduled sessions.

In total, we ran nine sessions, three focused on mentor training and six dedicated to group mentorship. After each session, we followed up with participants who were absent to understand the reasons for their absence and explore how we could support them. If participants did not respond to a phone call, we would follow up via WhatsApp to check if there were any problems.

Carry out surveys and tracking

We sent out three check-in surveys: benchmark, mid-point, and close-out, using the Zoom poll. After the midpoint and close-out sessions, we noticed that not all participants had completed their surveys as some experienced technical difficulties. To address this, we sent the surveys via Google Forms and followed up with participants through phone calls and two WhatsApp reminders.

Hold Closeout Call

We held the **7th**, and close-out calls on 26 and 27 August 2025, during which mentors and mentees provided feedback on the programme and expressed gratitude to one another.

Prepare Interim and Final Report

We prepared and submitted fortnightly reports that provided a comprehensive summary of the project's progress and highlighted key development.

Hold Operational Meetings

We held fortnightly meetings, with additional meetings scheduled only if rescheduling was required due to graduation or a Mancosa event.

Participation and attendance

Participation

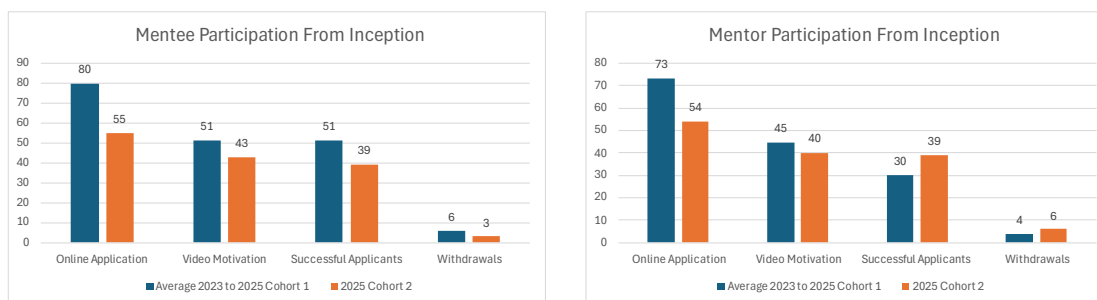
We received 55 mentee and 54 mentor applications, of which 43 mentees and 40 mentors submitted motivations. Among these, 1 mentee and 7 mentors were returning participants. One mentee and five mentors withdrew before the programme kicked off, leaving the programme to begin with 39 mentees and 31 mentors.

During the programme selection, 4 mentees and 1 mentor changed roles. There were additional withdrawals after the kick-off session of 2 mentees and 1 mentor.

Since its inception, the programme has attracted 1,007 applicants, 593 mentees and 414 mentors. We onboarded 626 participants, comprising 406 mentees and 220 mentors.

The mentorship community continues to grow steadily and becoming a valued asset to the university.

The graphs below compare the 2025 Cohort 2 with the average of the six cohorts from 2023 to 2025 cohort 1.



Comparing participation metrics between Cohort average of 2023–2025 and the 2025 Cohort 2 shows that Cohort 2 had fewer mentee applications (55 vs. 80) and successful applicants (39 vs. 51), but also slightly fewer withdrawals (3 vs. 6). For mentors, Cohort 2 had lower online applications (54 vs. 73), fewer video motivation submissions (40 vs. 45), and fewer successful applicants (30 vs. 39), with a small increase in withdrawals (6 vs. 4). These differences reflect historical trends: Cohort 2 generally attracts fewer participants because it primarily serves MBA students, while Cohort 1 has a higher proportion of undergraduate students. In Cohort 2, we implemented penalties for students who failed to participate, and this approach will be applied to future cohorts as well.

Applicant studies from inception

The tables below show mentee and mentor applicant numbers from 2023–2025, along with their studies. Mentees are mostly students at various levels, while mentors include alumni, current students, and professionals with diverse qualifications.

We excluded the 2022 mentee and mentor statistics because we did not request that information at the time.

Overall, both mentees’ and mentors’ participation has grown, reflecting the programme’s expanding reach.

Mentees’ study information from their applications:

Year / Cohort	Number of Mentees	Undergraduate	Postgraduate / Honours	Masters	MBA / MPA / MCom	PhD	Other
2023 C1	78	56	8	0	4	0	0
2023 C2	43	12	10	0	9	1	0
2024 C1	120	72	24	12	0	1	0
2024 C2	85	15	20	36	0	1	0
2025 C1	80	35	10	8	0	0	0
2025 C2	60	12	5	0	40	0	0
Subtotal	466	202	77	56	53	3	0

Mentors' study information from their applications:

Year / Cohort	Number of Mentors	Undergraduate	Postgraduate / Honours	Masters	MBA / MPA / MCom	PhD	Other
2023 C1	34	7	10	8	4	3	0
2023 C2	60	15	12	10	3	2	0
2024 C1	90	20	18	24	6	0	10
2024 C2	70	10	15	20	8	0	6
2025 C1	80	12	10	10	8	0	13
2025 C2	50	8	12	5	0	4	0
Subtotal	384	72	77	77	29	9	29

- Mentees are predominantly undergraduates, with a notable exception in Cohort 2 of each year, where they are primarily MBA and postgraduate students.
- Mentors generally have higher education levels (more with Masters, MBA/MPA/MCom, PhDs).
- Some mentors are listed as "undergraduate" – this indicates incomplete data updates on the Graduway platform.
- Mentor qualifications were verified via CVs despite some not updating their current studies/affiliation.

We included all applicants because the Mancosa Mentorship community comprises everyone who applied. While many applicants met the qualifications, we had limited spots and could not select everyone.

Attendance

On 9 July 2025, the programme kicked off with 39 mentees and 30 mentors. Participation across training and mentorship sessions stayed consistent.

• Training Sessions (mentors only):

- Attendance began with 24 mentors in Session 1, decreased by 1 to 23 in Session 2, and further to 19 in Session 3.
- The average mentor attendance across training sessions was 22 mentors.

• Group Mentorship Sessions:

- Mentee attendance ranged from 37 to 28 participants.
- Mentor attendance ranged from 26 to 20 participants.
- The average mentor attendance was 23 mentors, and the average mentee attendance was 32 mentees.

Group mentorship attendance

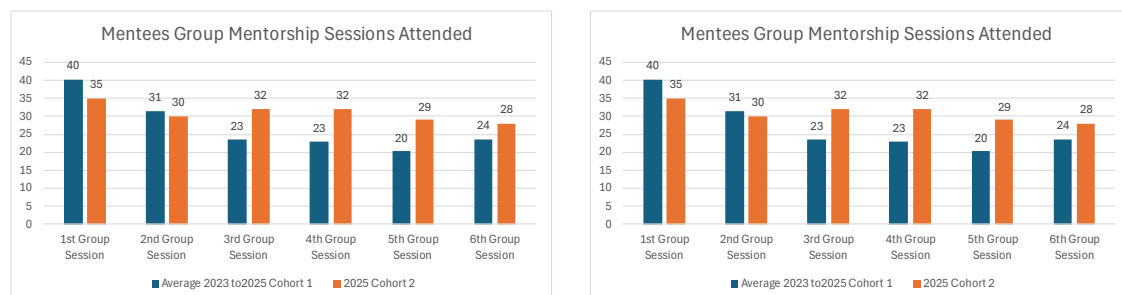
We ran the cohort with ten groups. Each group was assigned a colour-themed name. **Pink, Violet, Blue, and Red** showed the strongest engagement, with both mentees and mentors attending all sessions. **Black, Gray, and Brown** maintained moderate attendance, though some mentees missed sessions. **White, Purple, and Green** attended the fewest sessions, with frequent absences during

training and group mentorship. Mentees participated actively in early sessions, but attendance dipped in certain groups. Mentors stayed mostly consistent throughout, with a slight drop in later training sessions.

Attendance Trends from Inception

To gain insights into participants' commitment throughout the programme, we analyzed attendance data to track the number of sessions missed by both mentors and mentees since the programme's start. This helped us assess overall commitment and identify participation patterns. We conducted this analysis for the first time with the last cohort and are repeating it with the current cohort.

The table below shows the average attendance since the programme's inception compared with the 2025 Cohort 2 attendance.



The 2025 Cohort 2 generally had better or equal attendance in most Mentees Group Mentorship Sessions compared to the Average 2023-2025 Cohorts 1, except for the 1st Group Session where they had lower attendance. In Sessions 2 through 6, 2025 Cohort 2 either matched or outperformed the average attendance of the previous cohorts, with notable improvements in Sessions 5 and 6.

Certification

The Mancosa Mentorship Programme concluded with **39 mentees** and **30 mentors**. Mentees had 6 group sessions while mentors attended these sessions as well as 3 training sessions). To qualify for certification, participants needed to attend at least 80% of their sessions.

Mentees

- 29 mentees attended 80% of the sessions and therefore qualify for certification.
- 4 mentees attended 75% of the sessions, with reasons including work commitments, bereavement, health issues, and family responsibilities.
- 6 mentees are liable for the pro-rated fee, with reasons including time constraints, work commitments, bereavement and non-responsive.

Mentors

- 21 mentors attended 80% of the sessions and therefore qualify for certification.
- 3 mentors attended 75% of the sessions, with valid reasons including a car accident, mandatory site visit, and unstable connection.
- 6 mentors are liable for the pro-rated fee, with reasons including non-attendance without explanation, health issues, and inability to fully commit to the programme.

Programme impact

Mentorship Programme Surveys

Participants completed three surveys: a benchmark survey during the first session, a midway survey after the third session, and a closeout survey at the final session.

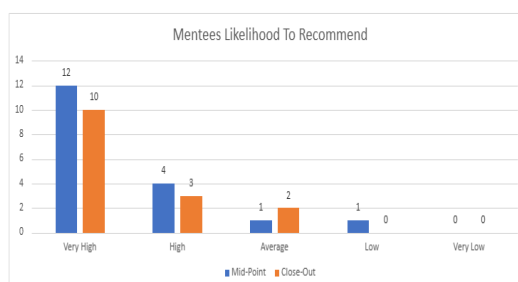
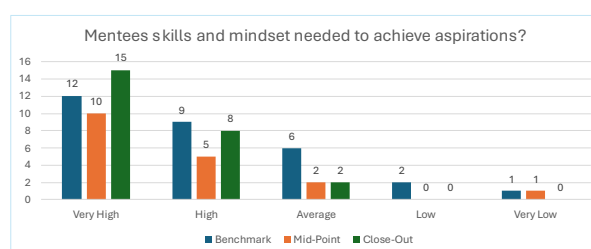
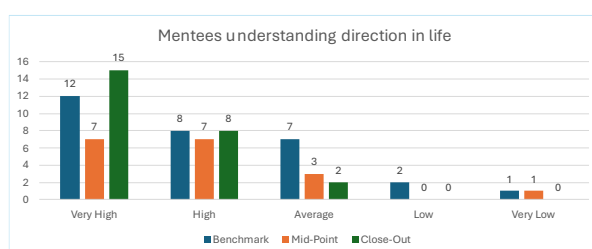
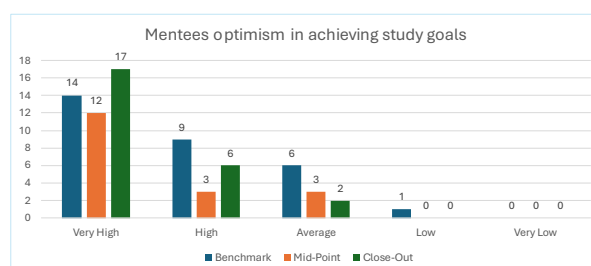
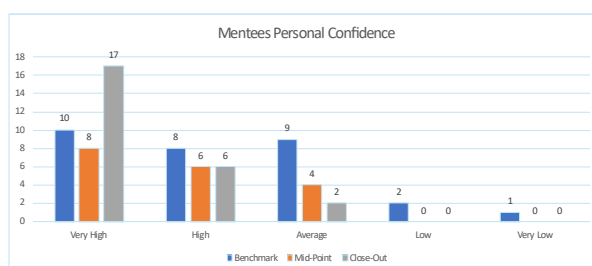
The results reveal meaningful growth for both mentees and mentors.

Mentee Insights

Mentees showed notable growth across personal confidence, optimism, career clarity, and skills/mindset:

- **Personal Confidence:** “Very High” ratings increased from 33% (10 out of 30) in the first survey to 68% (17 out of 25) at close-out
 - **Optimism in Achieving Study Goals:** Rose from 47% (14 out of 30) to 68% (17 out of 25).
 - **Understanding Direction in Life:** Increased from 40% (12 out of 30) to 60% (15 out of 25).
 - **Skills and Mindset for Aspirations:** Rose from 43% (12 out of 28) to 60% (15 out of 25).
- Likelihood to Recommend:** 87% (13 out of 15) rated their likelihood of recommending the programme as “Very High”.

The graphs below are a presentation of the participants' responses.

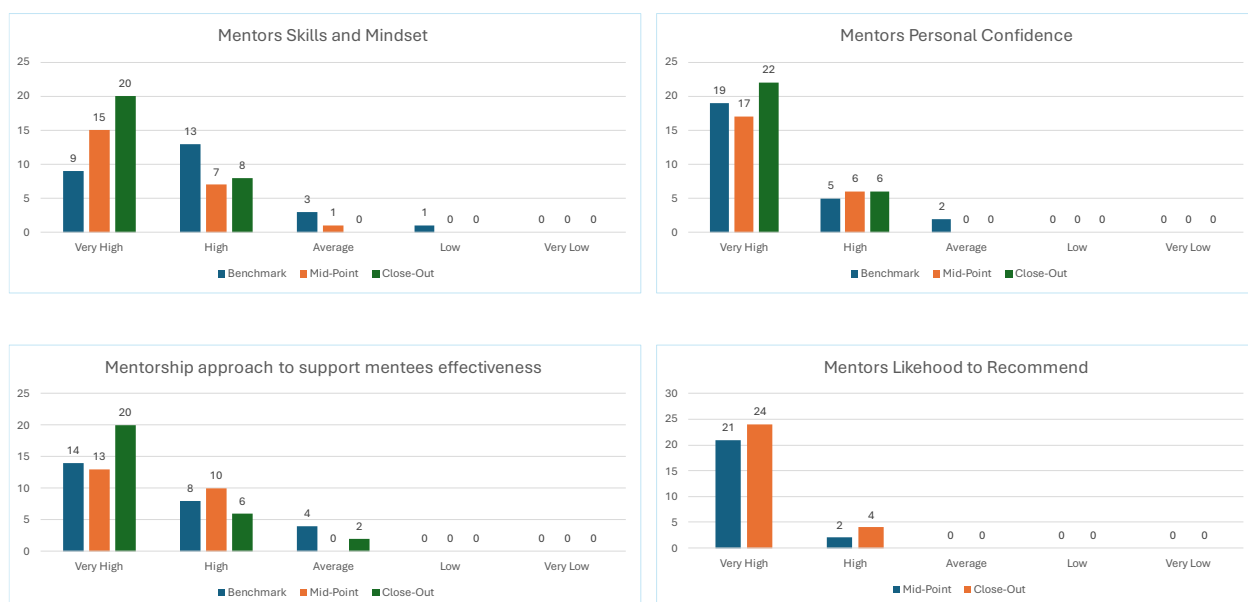


Mentor Insights

Mentors reported clear gains in confidence, direction, and mentoring effectiveness:

- **Skills and Mindset:** “Very High” ratings rose from 35% (9 out of 26) at benchmark to 71% (20 out of 28) at close-out.
- **Personal Confidence:** “Very High” ratings grew from 73% (19 out of 26) to 79% (22 out of 28).
- **Effectiveness in Supporting Mentees:** “Very High” ratings grew from 54% (14 out of 26) to 71% (20 out of 28).
- **Likelihood to Recommend:** All respondents to the close-out survey rated their likelihood of recommending the programme as “Very High” 86% (24 out of 28) or “High” 14% (4 out of 28).

The graphs below are a presentation of the participants' responses.



Comparing Growth: Mentees vs. Mentors

Both mentees and mentors experienced strong gains in confidence and skills/mindset. Mentees grew in career clarity and personal optimism while mentors showed significant improvement in mentoring ability.

Programme Impact

- Almost 90% of mentees and all mentors said they would “highly” or “very highly” recommend the programme.
- The surveys highlight the programme’s effectiveness in boosting confidence, clarity, and capability for both mentees and mentors.

Mentee and Mentor Feedback

At the close of each cohort, participants were invited to reflect on their journey, share their experiences, provide feedback, and acknowledge their groups. In the final group mentorship

sessions, both mentees and mentors offered valuable reflections on the programme.

Mentee Reflections

- This programme felt like therapy without the bill; it gave me a safe family-like space where I felt understood. From the very first session, I applied lessons like setting SMART goals, planning, and embracing authenticity. These tools helped me declutter both my academic and professional life and brought real clarity to my journey.
- The biggest high was realizing I was not alone. Sharing stories showed that while situations may differ, the struggles are similar. I learned that action matters more than qualifications, when you consistently show up and contribute, people see your true potential.
- The programme inspired deep personal growth. I gained confidence, confronted parts of my identity I had neglected, and built resilience. Where I once doubted myself, I now feel capable of facing challenges with belief and strength.
- At first, I thought I didn't need mentoring, but this programme proved me wrong. It revealed how important self-awareness and identity are, especially as a leader. The content felt tailored to my journey, and balancing multiple roles, I found both guidance and grounding that will shape me going forward.
- I joined with excitement but uncertainty, and I leave with clarity and invaluable lessons. Mentorship is a lifelong journey, and I now understand that at different stages you may need different kinds of guidance. The tools, resources, and reflections from this programme are ones I'll keep using for years to come.

Closeout sessions videos:

1. Tuesday [MANCOSA Group Session Tuesday 25 08 26 \(Dudu Phampha\).mp4](#)
2. Wednesday [MANCOSA Group Session Wednesday 25 08 27 \(Edited\).mp4](#)

Mentor Reflections

- The highlight of this journey was seeing the commitment of mentees who showed up prepared and engaged every session. One even discovered she wasn't the introvert she thought she was, finding confidence to speak openly. That kind of transformation shows the real power of mentorship and its impact on lives.
- Watching mentees grow and step out of their shells was inspiring, but equally meaningful was recognizing my own growth. Mentorship isn't just about giving advice; it's a two-way exchange of learning. What began as a struggle with mentees keeping cameras off turned into a breakthrough when they began switching them on willingly, showing how much confidence, they had gained.
- For me, the greatest reward was seeing consistent attendance. Each time people showed up, it was a reminder of the value they placed on this space and the respect for each other's time. Presence itself became the biggest gift.
- The biggest lesson was the importance of planning. As a multitasking mom, it wasn't always easy, but this programme reminded me to pause, smile, and embrace the moment. I also learned that putting myself first is essential, not selfish. This shift helped me finally take long-delayed steps

toward my studies and other priorities.

- This programme pushed me to pursue my DBA after years of postponing it. It also taught me the importance of structure, energy management, and protecting myself from burnout as a mentor. The honesty of accepting that you can only give what you have has been transformative.

Significantly, every mentor who spoke at the reflection session said they would be willing to mentor again next year.

Lessons learned and recommendations

As always, we applied lessons from past cohorts and identified opportunities to enhance the mentorship experience during the programme. The table below highlights key insights from the current cohort and the actions taken or planned in response. Notably, many of the strategies that proved effective in previous cohorts continued to deliver strong results in Cohort 7. This consistency meant there were fewer new lessons this time, reflecting that the programme is steadily evolving and improving with each iteration.

Cohort 7 Lessons Learned

Lesson Learned	Mitigation / Response
Late attendance to group mentorship sessions	The Ops team will participate in sessions as mentors or mentees before reassigning participants to other groups. We will also state in the commitment agreement that arriving early for sessions is mandatory.
Time constraints with multiple session slots	Running two sessions per week did not resolve the issue; it was the timing, not the day. Going forward, all participants will meet once a week on Wednesday from 17:00 to 18:30.
Participants missing sessions	Participants now sign a commitment agreement requiring at least 80% attendance. Failure to meet this may result in a prorated fee. This measure proved effective, as no withdrawals occurred after the second session.
Collecting participant feedback	Participants responded to surveys in real time and answered calls from programme admins, making feedback collection seamless.
Zoom poll technical issues	Admin will update Zoom poll questions and test the function before each session.

Ongoing Lessons That Continue to Work Effectively

Lesson Learned	Mitigation / Response
Flexible grouping supports continuity	Maintain the option for participants to join other groups if their own group cannot meet.
Real-time feedback (e.g., Zoom polls) enables quick improvements	Continue integrating live polls and track responses to guide future planning.
Structured pre- and post-session briefs add value	Retain structured briefs and debriefs as standard practice for mentors and mentees.
Returning mentors provide stability and quality	Recognize and prioritize returning mentors during recruitment and onboarding.
Connectivity limitations affect user experience	Remind participants to ensure a stable network connection to avoid dropping off sessions.
Improved application response time	Share mentorship programme application links via the student WhatsApp group to ensure faster access for newly registered students.
Group composition requests (e.g., gender balance)	Continue asking participants to specify gender (male, female, or prefer not to say) to ensure balanced groups.